🧠 Day 4: The 18 AI tools running my 8-figure business

1 message

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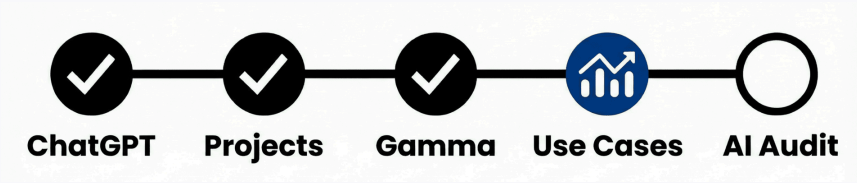

The Rundown University

Hey there,

Welcome to Day 4 of our 5-day introduction to AI email course!

Note: If you decide you want to go deeper than this free course, Rundown University gives you access to our full library of step-by-step workflow guides, certificate courses, and live workshops. You can try it free for 14 days by clicking here.

Yesterday, we showed you how to create professional presentations in a fraction of the time using ChatGPT and Gamma.

Today, I'm writing as Rowan, founder of The Rundown — pulling back the curtain to show you exactly how I use AI to run an 8-figure media company with 2M+ subscribers.

The journey

My friends and family call me the AI guy.

I didn't like it at first, but I've learned to embrace it.

Because in just over a year, I grew my Twitter/X account from scratch to over 500,000 followers by posting about the latest developments in AI, why they matter, and how you can apply it to your work.

That growth (and a whole lot of AI) helped me bootstrap The Rundown from nothing to 8 figures in revenue — landing me interviews with people like Mark Zuckerberg (CEO of Meta), Sam Altman (CEO of OpenAI), Satya Nadella (CEO of Microsoft).

But believe it or not, just a few years ago, I barely knew anything about AI.

I'm self-taught in basically everything I do — coding, design, content creation, marketing — all learned through the internet. But I thought AI was for nerds. No way was I going to be able to figure this stuff out.

Everything changed for me on April 22nd, 2022.

That was the day I first tried DALL-E 2, OpenAI's original image generation tool. The images it made look terrible compared to what we have now, but it was good enough to hit me with a realization that changed my entire approach to work:

"Why am I learning this if AI can just do it for me?"

This idea transformed the way I thought about work:

- Instead of spending hours editing content manually, I now use Claude as an editor who makes my writing sharper
- Instead of grinding through basic coding projects, I cut development time in half with Cursor and Claude Code
- Instead of wasting hours in Canva or outsourcing design, I create visual assets in seconds with Nano Banana and Ideogram

Me (Rowan) interviewing Satya Nadella (CEO of Microsoft) on the future of work

My AI stack

I dedicate every Sunday to testing and building with AI, so this is constantly getting refined, but here's what's sticking right now:

- **ChatGPT:** Real-time thinking partner for business and life decisions. I also keep Voice mode on while reading to clarify concepts, and use Vision to diagnose broken tech around the house
- **Custom GPTs:** Chatbots trained on Loom videos, SOPs, and internal docs to onboard new hires. Our motto: "Don't ask questions you haven't asked GPT first"
- **Claude:** Editor-in-chief for all my long-form writing. Go-to prompt: "make it better"

- **Claude Code**: Runs live Meta Ads analytics through an MCP server with a memory system that recalls past tests for faster ad iteration
- **Lindy AI**: Manages my calendar, books meetings via email, and drafts replies for FAQs and common customer questions
- **Notion AI**: My project management tool that organizes thoughts into actionable plans and generates pages for our AI tool database
- **n8n**: Advanced automations like filtering spam emails from genuine customer feedback and pinging appropriate team members in Slack
- **Wispr Flow**: Turns voice notes into polished writing based on my trained style
- **HeyGen + ElevenLabs**: Clones my face and voice for my AI avatar — helped me grow to 100k+ Instagram followers without filming myself
- **Gemini**: Auto-generates timestamps and finds clippable highlights from interviews
- **NotebookLM**: An AI tool by Google Labs that turns long research papers into engaging podcasts (I'm a nerd and like to listen to this stuff on long walks)
- **Cursor/Replit Agent**: AI development tools that help me spin up/build simple app prototypes in seconds
- **Perplexity Comet**: Lets me "chat" with YouTube videos and go into rabbit holes to fully grasp concepts
- **Granola**: Records, transcribes, and summarizes meetings into action items
- **Nano Banana**: Quick photo touch-ups that would normally require Photoshop
- **Gamma**: Instantly converts prompts and outlines into beautiful, structured presentations

What I've learned from integrating all these tools is that I don't actually work less — I work more, because of all the opportunities it unlocks.

I'd estimate AI adds the equivalent of 20 extra productive hours per week on top of the 60 I'm already putting in.

Hanging out with the world's biggest tech creators and the Google Gemini team (I'm on the far left)

The one thing that made this possible

I spend about 2 hours every Sunday specifically dedicated to exploring AI tools and figuring out how to integrate them into my work. Not random tinkering, focused time with a *specific* problem I want to solve.

That dedicated exploration time is how I stay ahead. The people who win in the AI age are the ones who stay curious and keep learning.

Tomorrow, we'll help you identify exactly where AI can have the biggest impact in your specific work using a simple 3-step audit.

See you then,

Rowan (founder of The Rundown)

Ready for the next step in your AI journey? Sign up for a 14-day free trial of Rundown University here.

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